

Chapter 33-1: Tears

Chu Qingqiu? Could it be that this Li Hanyan is planning to...

Ning Fuyi marveled at the audacity of this Hehuan Sect¹ leader. To dare use such sinister methods to provoke someone like Chu Qingqiu - was she tired of living?

"Sect Leader, when shall we act?" another person asked quietly.

"The time is about right. We'll act immediately to avoid complications from delays." Li Hanyan said while raising her chin slightly. The other person acknowledged with a "yes," and the two quickly disappeared into the shadows of the trees with their robes.

Ning Fuyi, however, found herself conflicted where she stood. Logically speaking, she didn't believe someone like Chu Qingqiu would be harmed by mere charm arts, but after all, she had personally witnessed her nearly falling for such tricks that day at the Ruyan Building.

Moreover, she shouldn't concern herself with such matters. Chu Qingqiu wasn't Liu Wenzhu² - why should she care about her life or death?

Besides, if she didn't take advantage of tonight when the Zhaoyang Saintess was indisposed to retrieve the Emei Thorn³, who knows if there would be another chance in the future.

With these thoughts, Ning Fuyi hardened her heart and continued leaping through the branches toward Shenyu⁴. However, she accidentally caught her sleeve on a tree branch, tearing it and leaving silk threads fluttering in the wind.

A thought quickly crossed her mind - she should have worn the clothes Chu Qingqiu had sewn for her, which would have been much more convenient. But as soon as this thought arose, she immediately stopped in place, her toes resting on a thin branch, staring at the torn fabric in a daze.

Ning Fuyi, you truly are beyond saving. She pressed her lips together and stood in the pitch-black night, her phoenix eyes cold and sharp, as if merging with the darkness itself.

After a while, she suddenly turned around, her robes fluttering behind her, her ghostly figure passing through the moonlight that had appeared at some unknown time, heading straight for the Peach Blossom Garden.

Her cultivation was far inferior to those two, so she couldn't accurately track their location, nor could she contact Chu Qingqiu. So she simply went directly to Chu Qingqiu's residence - she only needed to give her a warning to be on guard.

The Peach Blossom Garden was indeed a vast expanse of peach blossom forest with no visible end, but it was far more lush and beautiful than the peach blossom forest at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate⁵. Countless spirit birds and spirit butterflies danced among the flower forest, and glowing peach petals fell with the wind, accumulating on the ground in clusters of pink mist.

Several pavilions stood scattered throughout this peach blossom forest, their flying eaves reaching over the flower branches and covered with petals, making the originally black eaves appear as if coated with a layer of pink frost.

Other places had no guards, but this area where the sect leaders resided was heavily guarded. Many disciples of the Tianji Sword Sect stood nearby, carrying lanterns and patrolling back and forth.

Seeing that this place was difficult to enter, Ning Fuyi hid nearby and thought for a moment, then took out a paper figure from her pouch. This paper figure was quite ugly - drawn by her own hand.

This spell was also her own creation from her previous life, somewhat different from puppet arts. It could transform the paper figure into the appearance of a real person, but after the time it takes to burn a stick of incense⁶, the paper figure would drift away as smoke and ash, leaving no traces.

So she lowered her head and chanted something, injecting a wisp of immortal power into the paper figure. The paper figure immediately transformed into a young girl with apricot-shaped face and peach-colored cheeks. Without saying anything to her, it lifted its skirts and walked toward the patrolling disciples.

Before she could see clearly, the paper figure went up and slapped the leader across the face. The disciple covered his face in shock, about to curse angrily, when the paper figure backhanded him with another slap.

This was truly unbearable. The disciple roared in fury to catch her, and the others swarmed after the girl, leaving a gap in the patrol network.

Ning Fuyi then cast an invisibility spell and vanished into the layers of pink mist.

At this hour, everyone was basically resting, either sleeping or meditating, so no one paid attention to her movements. But the entire Peach Blossom Garden was so vast and had so many pavilions that without a guide, Ning Fuyi truly couldn't find Chu Qingqiu's location.

So she had a sudden inspiration and hid behind a peach blossom tree, quietly calling out Bai Lin's⁷ name.

To her surprise, after only three calls, a white light flashed before her, and the little white tiger was already crouching at her feet, excitedly running in circles and wrapping her ankle with its fluffy tail.

"So good," Ning Fuyi said softly. She crouched down and petted Bai Lin's head. "Can you help me deliver a message to Chu Qingqiu?"

"Li Hanyan wants to use despicable arts against her. Tell her not to let her guard down tonight and to be careful." Ning Fuyi said.

The little white tiger looked at her with its big eyes, clearly not understanding.

"Charm arts, do you understand?" Ning Fuyi raised an orchid finger⁸ near her ear and made a coquettish pose, trying to explain to the little white tiger.

The little white tiger still looked at her with its eyes and even licked its lips.

Never mind. Ning Fuyi wearily lowered her finger and gestured for Bai Lin to lead the way. This time Bai Lin understood, happily raising its tail and turning to run.

Ning Fuyi followed it all the way to the most secluded area, where stood a three-story pavilion. The pavilion was carved with openwork all around, with light gauze replacing windows. When the wind blew, the gauze would flutter gracefully, like entering a fairyland.

She quickly walked up the pavilion. Moonlight filtered through the light gauze onto the ground, as if scattered silver fragments. Qiu Yi⁹ was lying on an imperial concubine couch on the first floor, sleeping soundly. Ning Fuyi only slightly concealed her aura and stepped over her, going up to the top floor.

Footnotes:

1. **Hehuan Sect (合欢宗)** - Literally "Joyous Union Sect," a cultivation sect that practices charm and seduction arts
2. **Liu Wenzhu (柳文竹)** - A character from earlier in the story whom Ning Fuyi cared about
3. **Emei Thorn (峨眉刺)** - Ning Fuyi's signature weapon, a type of thin, needle-like weapon
4. **Shenyu (神陨)** - Literally "Divine Meteor," a location name
5. **Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate (云际山门)** - The mountain sect where the story's main characters are affiliated
6. **Time to burn a stick of incense** - Traditional Chinese time measurement, approximately 30-45 minutes
7. **Bai Lin (白麟)** - Literally "White Qilin," Chu Qingqiu's white tiger companion
8. **Orchid finger** - A delicate finger gesture associated with feminine grace and coquettishness in Chinese culture
9. **Qiu Yi (秋亦)** - A character who serves Chu Qingqiu